



FOCUS ON... **SILICON**

This semi-metal can be used to make hard and soft materials.



▲ Sandpaper is made from a compound of silicon and carbon called carborundum.



▲ These cupcake cases containing silicon can be put in an oven as they are heatproof.



▲ Silica gel packets are added to dry food, clothes, and shoes, to absorb moisture.

Silicon

14
Si

After oxygen, this semi-metal is the second most common element in Earth's rocks. Compounds of oxygen and silicon are called silicates and there are hundreds of different types. Around 90 per cent of all minerals inside rocks are silicates.

ATOMIC MASS 28.085

STATE Solid

DISCOVERY 1824 (Baron Jöns Jacob Berzelius)

The shiny surface of opal is from microscopic silicate crystals.

Piece of opal, a silicon compound

